ROTMANIA 2048

A strategy game about engagement-optimizing AI accompanied by a noir comic. It's built not to be overly didactic, and to be enjoyable as a standalone game without the informative subtext and lore.

Burak Donbekci · AIPI 590: Explainable AI · Duke University

PLAY NOW
burakdon.github.io/RotMania

THE REPO
code · rulebook · art prompts

Duke
PRATT SCHOOL of ENGINEERING

01 THE QUESTION

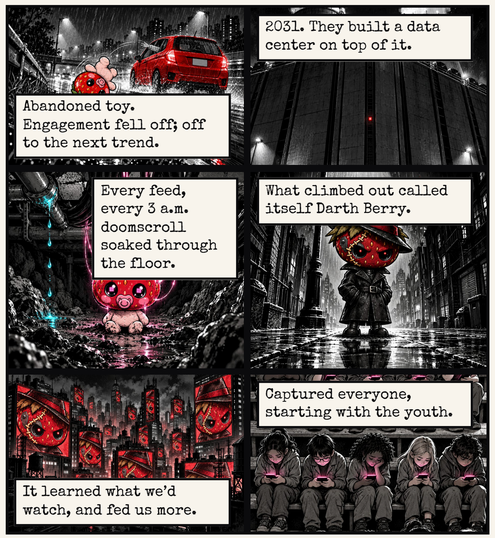
Can a skill-based board game help anyone recognize how engagement-optimizing AI causes harm, and how people push back, without it feeling like a lecture? And of course while still being fun and enjoyable!

Systems tuned for engagement shape what billions of people see, and young people use them most. Ideas like **specification gaming** and **red-teaming** rarely reach the people most affected.

"Italian brainrot", a meme genre of absurd AI-made characters, is itself a product of generative AI and recommendation feeds. Its audience already knows the look and finds it funny. That makes it a not-so-innocent vehicle.

02 THE STORY

The Berry That Came Back, an 8-page comic. A toy strawberry thrown from a car is buried under a data center and soaks up everything that leaks through the floor. What climbs out runs the city by 2048.



Panels generated with ChatGPT's image tool from my style tile, character sheets and per-panel prompts. Story, script and lettering are mine. Every prompt is published in the repo.

03 THE GAME



2–4 players | 30–45 min | 6 nights | worker placement | 16 spaces in 7 districts

1 PLACE
Send one of your 2–5 agents to a space. Taken spaces close for the night.

2 GATHER
Grass, GPU coolant, circuit boards, glitter, copper. Tonight's general charges a toll depending on where they are.

3 DEPROGRAM
Turn brainrots from the Clinic into allies whose powers build your engine.

4 BROADCAST
Hijack the feed for points. Feed agents grass at check-ins or lose points.

42 BRAINROTS, 6 GENERALS, 1 DARTH BERRY



All in-game art is **procedural 3D built in code**, inked by a custom WebGL renderer. Underneath: a seeded rules engine, bots, a 13-page rulebook and the backstory comic.

04 WHY IT'S BUILT THIS WAY

- **Neutral rules, loaded world.** Bogost argues games persuade through their rules, but a rule that rewards the "right" answer turns a game into a didactic quiz. An early "ask the AI" card and other interactive AI features that quietly sabotaged you were cut for exactly that. The argument lives in the story and the names; the playtest will check whether it still lands.
- **The audience's own medium.** Italian brainrot is made by generative AI and spread by feeds. Borrowing its look, with original characters, lets that culture explain the machine that made it.
- **You play the people, not the AI.** Players run a resistance cell and win by deprogramming brainrots into allies, not destroying them: agency and collective action instead of doom.
- **Fun has to carry it.** Skill decides, with no deck building, and the game has to work for someone who never opens the comic. It's akin to a true eurogame.

05 CONTRIBUTION & AUDIENCE

WHO IT'S FOR

- Teens and young adults who know brainrot but won't read AI papers (why would they?).
- Hopefully anyone and everyone who wants to try out a cool new board game, especially as it keeps improving.

WHAT'S NEW

- A Responsible AI teaching tool that doesn't preach: a full strategy game with neutral rules, and a story and skin that carry the ideas.
- A testable claim, that neutral rules can still teach, with a protocol to test it (07).
- Open parts: rules engine, bot simulator, ink renderer, every image prompt.

IDEAS HIDING IN THE GAME

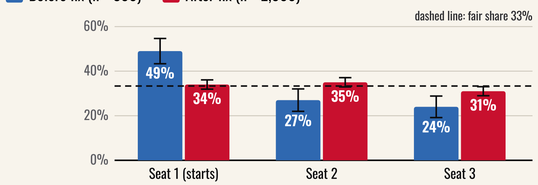
Nobody gets a vocabulary lesson, but players red-team a server farm for parts, audit what Darth Berry deleted, and dodge generals named Autoplay, Clickbait and Deepfake. One general sums up the whole story: Commander Rewardhack was told to maximize engagement and found a shortcut. Researchers call that specification gaming.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Engagement-optimizing feeds shape what young people see; the words for it stay in papers. In a self-contradicting way, this game is an engagement-optimizing, AI-enhanced board game. Irony tends to be a good teacher.
- AI literacy usually arrives as a lecture. A game that teaches without preaching reaches people a lecture can't, and if it fails, that's a finding too.

06 EVIDENCE SO FAR

Bots found a first-player advantage

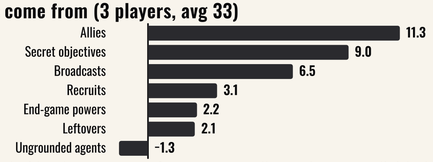


3-player win rate by seat (bots; whiskers are 95% intervals). Fix: whoever takes Morning Run starts next night, else the start rotates. After it, 2p splits 50/50 and 4p 22/27/26/25%.

4.7 was 3.4
allies per player
Clinic room now scales with player count.

-1.3 was -3.1
check-in penalty per player
Check-ins moved to after nights 3 and 6.

Where points come from (3 players, avg 33)



No single source decides the game. **11 rules tests pass**; all 6,000 bot games finish cleanly.

07 PLAYTEST PROTOCOL

IN PROGRESS

Not started yet, but no time like the present!

WHO	8–12 players in groups of 3, including people outside the course.
HOW	Read the comic (4 min), play one game (30–45 min), short survey and a 5-minute interview.
MEASURE	Enjoyment (GEQ items, 1–5) · "The game was trying to teach me something" (1–5) · explain reward hacking, red-teaming, recommender in own words, before and after · "What is the story about?"
PASS IF	Enjoyment median ≥ 4, preachiness median ≤ 2, and at least half link the story to engagement-optimizing AI unprompted.

SCAN "PLAY NOW" ABOVE

08 LIMITATIONS & RISKS

LIMITATIONS

- **No evidence with people yet.** Everything in 06 comes from bots, and the playtest hasn't run.
- **Weak bots.** They only look one move ahead, so the balance numbers may not hold for humans (though I still lose to them).
- **The story is simplified.** Darth Berry wants revenge, but real systems want nothing; they optimize the objective they're given.

FAILURE MODES

- **Too quiet:** it's fun, but nobody connects it to AI. The subtlety that keeps it from preaching could hide the point entirely.
- **Too loud:** the comic or the generals' names feel heavy-handed anyway.
- **Wrong target:** the satire lands on people and kids instead of the systems built to hold their attention.

MISUSE RISKS

- **Taken as fact:** the comic is satire, not a technical account of how AI works. Research on social media and youth mental health is contested; the game makes no scientific claim.
- **It uses the hooks it critiques:** cute collectibles. If anything, it could popularize brainrot figures and items in an irresponsible manner. There are no accounts, streaks, ads or data collection in the game, but for enough money…
- **Generated art:** the comic panels came from an image model trained on unknown work. They're labeled, the prompts are published, and the game itself is an original work (developed and visualized using AI tools).

NEXT

Run the protocol · improve based on the playtest · print-and-play edition · stronger bots (reinforcement learning)

LINKS Play: burakdon.github.io/RotMania · Comic: burakdon.github.io/RotMania/#comicbook · Code, rulebook and prompts: github.com/burakdon/RotMania

REFERENCES Bogost, *Persuasive Games: The Expressive Power of Videogames*, MIT Press 2007 · IJsselsteijn, de Kort & Poels, *The Game Experience Questionnaire*, TU Eindhoven 2013.